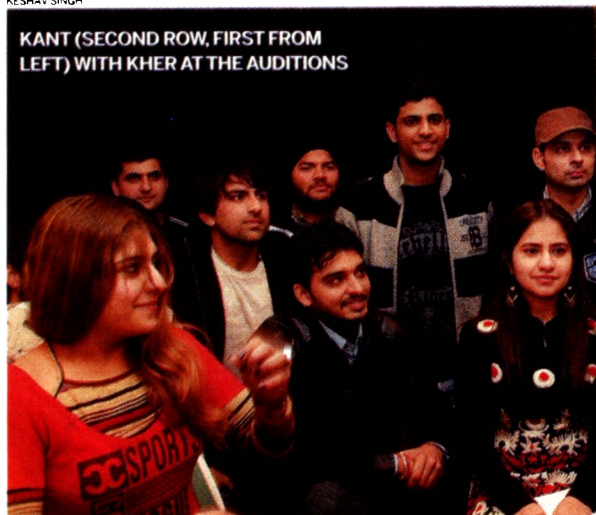


Aspiring Actors *Chandigarh*

Bachelors of Art

When Laali completes his computer engineering course, his father will be a happy man. But not the 22-year-old. "Why would I want to be in a field that is so crowded? It isn't who I am," he says. So he is auditioning for a place at Anupam Kher's acting school in Chandigarh. Actor Prepares. He's one among several who have come from towns such as Hoshiarpur and Roorkee, a touch nervous but not unsettled by the famous actor. "Today's youngsters are so confident," says the 54-year-old who has to choose between two kinds of aspirants: rich landlords' sons and serious actors. All of them want to follow their hearts, even though they know they might hurt their parents in the process. Like 19-year-old Twinkle Madaan from Panipat, who is doing a course in export management because it is expected, even though acting is where her soul sings. "I am willing to starve for 10 days to per-

KESHAV SINGH



suade my parents," she says. It's the same with Rajni Kant, 21, from Hisar "where people are happy with their routine, working, eating and sleeping. But that's not life." He wants to be famous. Even if it costs Rs 98,000 for three months. And even if it means a career switch. **by Arvind Chhabra**

DREAM

To pursue their choices, even if they are unconventional



"People in Hisar are happy with the routine of work, eat, sleep. But I want to be famous."

RAJNI KANT Young Actor

Vidya Niketan *Bangalore*

World Warriors

Mukta Batra has never been to Moscow. But last year in Singapore, the lawyer's daughter was found articulating the foreign policy of a nation that gave the world words like glasnost and perestroika. The 17-year-old, who walked away with the best delegate award, is among hundreds of schoolchildren

"I want to leverage my skills and help articulate issues that will project India in a better light."

MUKTA BATRA

Delegate Model United Nations

DREAM

To see India play an active role globally

SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN



BATRA (EXTREME RIGHT) AND VARSHA (TOP LEFT) WITH OTHER STUDENT DELEGATES

who have benefited from Model United Nations (MUNs), a UN programme that was introduced in their school Vidya Niketan five years ago. Whether it is a hot debate on the Cold War or a detailed discussion on multilateralism in a unipolar world, these children are proving to be global diplomats in the making. "The India of the future is all about knowledge-based economies," says another student, Varsha R.S., 17. Which is why they want to "do more" than just mug from textbooks and become one-trick ponies. "MUN forces us to read a lot and do research," says Batra. "These skills come in handy in giving us opportunities to talk about real life situations," points out Varsha. It also helps them score US university scholarships and follow seemingly unlikely role models such as Amartya Sen and Jagdish Bhagwati. **by Stephen David**